west is an open, semi-rural area stretching all the way to the Agra Fort. This area has been protected as the "Taj Protected Forest" in order to maintain the historic landscape around these two world heritage sites.

There are numerous gates to enter the complex, all dramatic and in a style similar to the famous main gate of the Mausoleum. Called an "iwan", it involves a large ceremonial, decorated arch with a smaller door inside it. The Taj Ganji area within the gates is a bustling bazaar area that was designed in the earliest plans to service the needs of the planned visitors with a market and caravanserai (the equivalent of today's hotels). Throughout the Muslim world, these types of institutions are often constructed alongside a mosque or shrine-tomb, and the money made there is at least partly used for the maintenance of the facility. The resulting closeness between bazaar and charitable institution in the Persian world was seen in modern times in the merchant-priest alliance that was a central core of the Iranian Islamic Revolution of 1979[25]. Today, this area - which is sometimes called Mumtazabad - remains a marketplace teeming with life[26], and it's popular for its budget accommodations and backpacker clientele (tour groups enter from side gates).

The Forecourt (Jilaukhana)

Next, visitors pass through another, grander set of gates and enter a more formal area, today known as the Forecourt or Jilaukhana. This area was designed to be the home of attendants who worked in the Taj facility - a step above the bazaaris of the Taj Ganji but economically tied to them. The buildings and grounds of the tomb and surrounding facilities needed (and still need) constant maintenance, but today, the city of Agra has grown to come right up to the southern gates of the Taj and modern transport means that a class of in-house servants was no longer needed.

There is a small bazaar here, with two colonnaded streets that, until recently, held shops that supported the complex. Additionally, this area has two lesser tombs which appear like miniature versions of the main mausoleums and are said to hold two of Shah Jahan's less favored wives.

On the far side of the Jilaukhana from the Taj Ganji is the entrance to the formal gardens. Called the "Great Gate," ("Darwaza-i rauza") it is an iwan constructed of red sandstone with white marble highlights, a fusion of the style of the red outer walls and echoes of what is to come. By this point, visitors